

Singapore Section of the Combustion Institute (SSCI)

Young Investigator Award

Governing Guidelines

Effective from: 2026

Approved by: SSCI Committee

Award frequency: Annual

Award amount: SGD 500

1. Purpose of the Award

The **SSCI Young Investigator Award** is established by the Singapore Section of the Combustion Institute (SSCI) to recognise outstanding young researchers who have made significant research contributions to combustion science and engineering while being based in Singapore.

The award aims to:

1. recognise outstanding research achievements by young members of the SSCI;
2. encourage excellence, creativity and innovation in combustion research;
3. support and motivate the next generation of combustion researchers in Singapore;
4. strengthen the engagement of young researchers with the SSCI and the wider combustion community; and
5. provide an annual platform for recognising emerging research talent within Singapore.

The award shall normally be presented at the **SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting**.

2. Award

The SSCI Young Investigator Award shall consist of:

- an **award prize of SGD 500**;
- an official **SSCI Young Investigator Award certificate**; and
- formal recognition at the **SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting**.

The SSCI Committee may additionally provide a physical trophy, plaque or other form of recognition, subject to availability of funds and approval by the Committee.

Up to two awardees shall normally be selected in each award year.

The SSCI Committee reserves the right not to make an award in a particular year if, in its judgement, no candidate meets the required standard.

3. Eligibility

3.1 General eligibility

To be eligible for consideration, a candidate must:

1. be an **active member of the Singapore Section of the Combustion Institute (SSCI) on 1 January of the award year**;
2. be a **PhD student, post-doctoral research fellow, research fellow, research scientist, or equivalent early-career researcher**;
3. be conducting research or working at a **Singapore-based university, research institute, government agency, or industry organisation**;
4. have made substantive contributions to combustion science, combustion engineering, energy conversion, propulsion, fire science, or closely related areas relevant to the mission of the Singapore Section of the Combustion Institute; and
5. satisfy the career-stage requirement specified in Section 3.2.

Membership of the SSCI shall be verified by the SSCI Committee or its designated officer.

3.2 Career-stage requirement

The award is intended for researchers at the early stage of their independent or emerging research careers.

A candidate shall normally be eligible if, on the nomination deadline:

- they are currently enrolled as a PhD student; or
- they are **within 3 years of the award of their PhD degree** and hold a post-doctoral, research fellow, research scientist or equivalent position.

Career interruptions, including parental leave, national service, extended medical leave or other formally recognised career interruptions, may be taken into account when determining eligibility.

The SSCI Committee may make reasonable adjustments to the career-stage criterion in exceptional circumstances, provided that the decision is documented.

3.3 Nationality

There shall be **no nationality restriction** for the award.

The primary eligibility requirement is that the candidate is an eligible young SSCI member **based in Singapore.**

3.4 Previous awardees

A previous recipient of the SSCI Young Investigator Award shall not be eligible to receive the same award again.

4. Nomination

4.1 Call for nominations

The SSCI Committee shall issue an annual call for nominations.

The call shall normally be circulated through:

- the SSCI membership mailing list;
- the SSCI website and/or official communication channels;
- relevant Singapore combustion research networks; and
- other channels deemed appropriate by the SSCI Committee.

The call shall specify:

1. the eligibility requirements;
2. the nomination deadline;
3. the required nomination materials;
4. the evaluation criteria;
5. the expected date and venue of the award ceremony; and
6. the name or contact point of the SSCI officer responsible for receiving nominations.

4.2 Who may nominate

A candidate may be nominated by:

- an SSCI member;
- a faculty member, supervisor, principal investigator or research leader;
- a researcher or professional in a relevant field; or
- another individual approved by the SSCI Committee.

Self-nomination shall not be permitted.

4.3 Nomination materials

Each nomination shall normally include:

1. **Nomination form**;
2. **Curriculum vitae** of the candidate;
3. **Research statement** of no more than 2 pages describing the candidate's major research contributions and their significance;
4. list of selected publications and other research outputs;
5. description of major achievements, awards, patents, software, technology development or other relevant contributions, where applicable; and
6. **nomination letter** explaining why the candidate should receive the award.

The SSCI Committee may specify additional materials where appropriate, but should avoid imposing an excessive administrative burden on candidates.

5. Evaluation Criteria

Candidates shall be evaluated primarily on the **quality, significance and originality of their research contributions**, rather than simply on publication quantity.

The following criteria shall normally be considered:

Criterion	Suggested Weight
Research quality and scientific contribution	30%
Originality, innovation and creativity	25%
Research impact and significance	20%
Research productivity and achievements	15%
Contribution to Singapore's combustion community and potential for future leadership	10%
Total	100%

The Committee may adjust the weighting for a particular award cycle, provided that the criteria and weighting are established **before evaluation begins** and are applied consistently to all candidates.

5.1 Research quality and scientific contribution

The Committee should consider:

- scientific depth and rigour;
- importance of the research problem;
- quality of research methodology;
- advancement of fundamental understanding or engineering knowledge; and
- contribution to combustion science and/or related disciplines.

5.2 Originality and innovation

The Committee should consider:

- originality of research ideas;
- innovative experimental, theoretical or computational approaches;
- development of new methodologies, technologies or tools; and
- ability to address challenging scientific or engineering problems.

5.3 Research impact and significance

Impact may include:

- influence on the scientific community;
- industrial or technological relevance;
- contribution to energy transition, decarbonisation, safety or sustainability;
- adoption of research methods or technologies; and
- other demonstrable academic or societal impact.

5.4 Productivity and achievements

The Committee may consider:

- quality and significance of publications;
- patents and technology outputs;
- research awards;
- conference contributions;
- research funding or project contributions; and
- other recognised research achievements.

Publication count alone shall not determine the outcome.

5.5 Community contribution and future potential

The Committee may consider:

- contribution to the SSCI and Combustion Institute;
- participation in conferences and scientific activities;
- mentoring or collaboration with other young researchers;
- leadership in research activities; and
- demonstrated potential to become a future leader in combustion research.

6. Award Selection Panel

6.1 Composition

The SSCI Committee shall establish an **SSCI Young Investigator Award Selection Panel** each year.

The Selection Panel shall normally comprise **3–5 members**, including:

- the SSCI Chair or the Chair's nominee;
- at least one additional member of the SSCI Committee; and
- one or more senior researchers or academic members of the local or overseas combustion community.

Where practical, the Selection Panel should include members from more than one Singapore institution.

The SSCI Chair shall appoint the Selection Panel annually.

6.2 Independence

The Selection Panel shall make its recommendation based on the published evaluation criteria and shall exercise independent academic judgement.

The Selection Panel shall not be required to disclose detailed rankings or individual scores to nominees.

6.3 Chair of the Selection Panel

The SSCI Chair shall normally designate one member of the Selection Panel as **Selection Panel Chair**.

The Panel Chair shall:

- coordinate the evaluation process;
- ensure that conflicts of interest are properly managed;
- ensure consistent application of the criteria;
- oversee scoring and deliberation; and
- submit the final recommendation to the SSCI Committee.

7. Conflict of Interest

A Selection Panel member shall declare any actual, potential or perceived conflict of interest.

A conflict may arise, for example, where the candidate:

- is a current or recent PhD student or post-doctoral researcher supervised by the Panel member;
- is a current close collaborator;

- is a member of the Panel member's research group;
- has a close personal or professional relationship with the Panel member; or
- has another relationship that could reasonably affect, or appear to affect, impartial judgement.

A Panel member with a significant conflict of interest shall:

1. declare the conflict to the Selection Panel Chair;
2. withdraw from discussion and scoring of the relevant candidate; and
3. not participate in the final decision concerning that candidate.

Where the Panel Chair has a conflict of interest, the SSCI Chair shall appoint another Panel member to oversee the relevant part of the process.

All conflicts of interest and the actions taken to manage them shall be recorded.

8. Evaluation Procedure

The annual selection shall normally follow the procedure below.

Stage 1 — Call for nominations

The SSCI Committee announces the award and opens nominations.

Stage 2 — Eligibility screening

The Selection Panel or its designated administrator verifies:

- SSCI membership;
- Singapore-based status;
- career-stage eligibility; and
- completeness of the nomination.

Candidates failing to meet the eligibility requirements shall not proceed to substantive evaluation.

Stage 3 — Independent assessment

Each eligible candidate shall normally be assessed independently by at least **three Selection Panel members**, subject to conflicts of interest.

Each assessor shall provide:

- a score based on the approved criteria; and
- brief comments supporting the assessment.

Stage 4 — Panel deliberation

The Selection Panel shall meet to discuss the candidates and determine the ranking.

The Panel should consider both numerical scores and qualitative assessment. Numerical scores shall **not automatically determine the winner** where the Panel considers that qualitative differences in research significance or originality warrant further discussion.

Stage 5 — Recommendation

The Selection Panel shall recommend one candidate to the SSCI Committee.

The recommendation should include:

- the name of the recommended awardee;
- a brief justification;
- the evaluation outcome; and
- confirmation that conflicts of interest have been appropriately managed.

Stage 6 — Final approval

The SSCI Committee shall formally approve the recommendation.

The SSCI Committee shall normally accept the Selection Panel's recommendation unless there is evidence of:

- procedural irregularity;
- failure to comply with eligibility requirements;
- significant conflict of interest; or
- other circumstances that materially compromise the integrity of the selection process.

The SSCI Committee shall not normally substitute its own academic ranking for that of the Selection Panel.

9. Tie and Borderline Cases

If two candidates are closely ranked, the Selection Panel should first seek to reach a consensus through discussion.

If a consensus cannot be reached, the Panel may use the following order of consideration:

1. significance of scientific contribution;
2. originality and innovation;
3. demonstrated research impact;
4. potential for future leadership; and

5. overall research achievement.

If the candidates remain indistinguishable, the Selection Panel may recommend:

- one candidate;
- a joint award, if exceptional circumstances justify it; or
- no award.

If two awardees are selected, each awardee will be presented the SGD 500 prize, unless the SSCI Committee approves an alternative arrangement.

10. Confidentiality

All nomination and evaluation materials shall be treated as confidential.

Selection Panel members shall not disclose:

- individual scores;
- confidential comments;
- deliberations;
- rankings; or
- information about unsuccessful candidates

outside the selection process.

The names of unsuccessful candidates shall not normally be publicly disclosed.

The SSCI may retain nomination and evaluation records for institutional purposes, subject to applicable Singapore data-protection requirements and SSCI policies.

11. Announcement of the Award

The awardee shall normally be announced at the **SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting**.

The SSCI may announce the awardee through:

- the SSCI website;
- SSCI newsletters;
- social media or other official communication channels;
- conference materials; or
- other appropriate professional communications.

The announcement should include a concise citation describing the awardee's major contribution.

12. Award Ceremony

The award shall normally be presented during the **SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting**.

The award ceremony should include:

1. announcement of the award;
2. presentation of the certificate and SGD 500 prize;
3. citation of the awardee's achievements; and
4. a photograph or other appropriate record of the presentation.

Where practical, the awardee should be invited to give a short presentation on their research at the Annual Combustion Meeting.

The awardee's presentation is intended to promote interaction between young researchers and the wider SSCI community and is not intended to constitute an additional assessment.

13. Financial Administration

The award prize shall be **SGD 500 per awardee**.

The SSCI Treasurer or designated financial officer shall administer the prize payment in accordance with the financial procedures of the SSCI and the Combustion Institute.

The prize may be paid by:

- bank transfer;
- cheque; or
- another approved payment method.

The awardee shall provide any information reasonably required for processing the payment.

Any applicable tax or reporting obligation shall be handled in accordance with relevant Singapore requirements and the policies of the organisation administering the award.

14. Annual Timeline

The following timeline shall normally be used:

Activity	Indicative Timing
SSCI Committee confirms award cycle and Selection Panel	4–5 months before Annual Meeting
Call for nominations	3–4 months before Annual Meeting
Nomination deadline	2–3 months before Annual Meeting
Eligibility screening	Within 2 weeks after deadline
Independent evaluation	2–4 weeks
Selection Panel deliberation	4–6 weeks before Annual Meeting
SSCI Committee approval	Within 2 weeks after Panel recommendation
Awardee notified	At least 2 weeks before Annual Meeting
Award presentation	SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting
Public announcement	At or shortly after Annual Meeting

The SSCI Committee may modify the dates to accommodate the actual date of the Annual Combustion Meeting.

15. Records and Documentation

The SSCI shall maintain an annual record of the award process containing, as appropriate:

- the approved call for nominations;
- list of nominees;
- eligibility screening outcome;
- Selection Panel membership;
- conflict-of-interest declarations;
- evaluation results;
- Selection Panel recommendation;
- SSCI Committee approval; and
- final awardee information.

The records shall be maintained in an appropriate SSCI administrative repository.

16. Review of the Award

The SSCI Committee shall review the Young Investigator Award periodically to ensure that:

- the award remains relevant to the SSCI community;
- the eligibility requirements remain appropriate;
- the evaluation criteria remain fair and effective;

- the award attracts strong nominations;
- the prize remains appropriate; and
- the selection process continues to meet appropriate standards of transparency and integrity.

A formal review should normally be undertaken at least once every **three years**, or earlier if requested by the SSCI Committee.

Changes to these Governing Guidelines require approval by the SSCI Committee.

17. Amendment and Approval of the Award Guidelines

17.1 Approval of the Governing Guidelines

These Governing Guidelines shall be approved by the **SSCI Committee** before the SSCI Young Investigator Award is launched.

The approved version shall constitute the official governing document for the award and shall be followed by the SSCI Committee and the Selection Panel.

17.2 Proposed Amendments

Any proposed amendment to these Governing Guidelines or any substantive change to the SSCI Young Investigator Award, including but not limited to:

- eligibility requirements;
- award amount;
- award frequency;
- nomination and selection procedures;
- evaluation criteria;
- composition or appointment of the Selection Panel;
- conflict-of-interest requirements; or
- award presentation arrangements,

shall be submitted to the SSCI Committee for consideration and approval.

Proposed amendments should be circulated to SSCI Committee members sufficiently in advance of the Committee meeting at which they will be considered.

17.3 Approval of Amendments

Any substantive amendment to these Governing Guidelines or material change to the award shall require **formal approval by the SSCI Committee**.

The approved amendment shall be recorded in the minutes of the relevant SSCI Committee meeting.

Unless otherwise specified by the SSCI Committee, an approved amendment shall take effect from the **next award cycle** and shall not normally be applied retrospectively to an award cycle that has already commenced.

17.4 Administrative Changes

The SSCI Chair, in consultation with the SSCI Committee or its designated officer, may make minor administrative or editorial changes that do not alter the principles, eligibility, evaluation criteria, financial value, or governance of the award.

Such changes shall be reported to the SSCI Committee and recorded appropriately.

17.5 Version Control

Each approved version of the Governing Guidelines shall have:

- a version number;
- an approval date;
- an effective date; and
- a brief record of substantive amendments.

The latest SSCI Committee-approved version shall be regarded as the authoritative version of the Governing Guidelines.

17.6 Changes to the Award

Any proposal to establish, suspend, substantially modify, or discontinue the SSCI Young Investigator Award shall require approval by the SSCI Committee.

The Committee shall consider the implications for current and future award cycles before implementing any such change.

18. Recommended Annual Committee Checklist

The SSCI Committee should complete the following actions each award cycle:

- Confirm the award year and Annual Combustion Meeting date.
- Confirm the SGD 500 prize.
- Appoint the Young Investigator Award Selection Panel.
- Confirm Selection Panel members' conflicts of interest.
- Approve the annual call for nominations.
- Confirm the nomination deadline.
- Verify SSCI membership and eligibility of all nominees.
- Distribute eligible nominations to Selection Panel members.
- Collect independent evaluations.
- Conduct Selection Panel deliberation.

- Record and manage all conflicts of interest.
- Receive the Selection Panel's recommendation.
- Approve the awardee through the SSCI Committee.
- Notify the successful candidate.
- Prepare the certificate and SGD 500 prize.
- Prepare the award citation.
- Present the award at the SSCI Annual Combustion Meeting.
- Announce the award through SSCI's official communication channels.
- Archive the annual award records.

Document status: Governing document

Responsible body: SSCI Committee

Review cycle: At least every three years

Version: 1.0

Approval date: __ 8 Sept, 2026 __

Appendix A — Suggested Award Citation

SSCI Young Investigator Award [Year]

*The Singapore Section of the Combustion Institute Young Investigator Award is presented to **[Name]** in recognition of outstanding contributions to **[research area]**, particularly for **[brief description of major contribution]**, and for demonstrating exceptional promise as a future leader in combustion science and engineering.*

Appendix B — Suggested Evaluation Form

Candidate: _____

Evaluator: _____

Evaluation Criterion	Weight	Score
Research quality and scientific contribution	30%	/100
Originality, innovation and creativity	25%	/100
Research impact and significance	20%	/100
Research productivity and achievements	15%	/100
Contribution to the combustion community and future leadership	10%	/100
Overall weighted score	100%	/100

Overall assessment:

- ☐ Strongly recommend
☐ Recommend
☐ Recommend with reservations
☐ Do not recommend

Brief justification:

Conflict of interest declared:

- ☐ No
☐ Yes — details: _____

Evaluator signature: _____

Date: _____
